



Agencies push back on Musk’s email edict

Workers get conflicting guidance after again being told to justify jobs

BY EVAN HALPER,
DAN LAMOTHE
AND HANNAH NATANSON

Elon Musk is trying again on his demand that every federal worker justify their employment weekly. And again, the hastily executed initiative is sowing confusion and resistance throughout the workforce, with many agency heads openly defying it.

A second round of emails instructing more than 2 million workers to reply with bullet points listing five things they accomplished over the week, which Musk calls a “pulse check,” came a week after the billionaire charged with executing President Donald Trump’s cost-cutting directives warned those who did not respond to an identical order last weekend that it would be taken as a resignation.

Late Friday and into Saturday, the second round of pushback had already begun at a handful of agencies. Some resistance came from officials at the very highest levels.

NASA acting administrator Janet Petro wrote Friday to staff warning them that “government-wide communications may reach you before we receive clear implementation guidance,” according to a copy of her message reviewed by The Washington Post. If workers receive another such communication over the weekend, they should ignore it, Petro wrote.

“Please give yourself a moment, and when you’re back on duty, check in with your supervisor or other agency leader before taking action,” Petro wrote. “Ultimately, we want to reduce your stress and provide clarity as we work through these requests together.”

The State Department likewise sent a brief note early Saturday telling staff to do nothing with the

SEE DOGE ON A17



JOEL ANGEL JUAREZ/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Big flex, little effect at border

Facing Trump’s threat, Mexico sent 10,000 troops to stop fentanyl. It remains elusive.

BY MARY BETH SHERIDAN
IN NOGALES, MEXICO

When President Donald Trump threatened 25 percent tariffs unless Mexico put a halt to fentanyl trafficking, the government snapped to attention. Mexican President Claudia Sheinbaum dispatched an additional 10,000 national guard members to the border. For more than three weeks, troops have stopped nearly every U.S.-bound car leaving this city, questioning drivers, sliding mirrors under vehicles, poking fiber-optic scopes into gas tanks and walking drug-sniffing dogs around autos.

The result? The troops in Nogales have found 150 fentanyl pills, according to official statistics. Meanwhile, U.S. officials just across the border have seized more than 400,000.

Some critics have dismissed Mexico’s operation as a show, designed to placate an American leader fond of military solutions to complex prob-

lems. That misses the point, analysts say. Mexico appears to be making a serious effort to cooperate more on tackling fentanyl and other narcotics. On Thursday, for example, it transferred 29 high-level drug suspects to the United States.

But the border operation underscores the difficulty of finding the opioid — especially for a country with a weak, underfunded security structure.

The fentanyl epidemic is the deadliest in U.S. history. Overdose deaths attributed mostly to the opioid topped 100,000 in 2023, before dropping by more than 20 percent in the 12-month period ending in August, according to preliminary figures. The drug is largely made in small Mexican labs and is

highly concentrated, U.S. officials say.

That makes it frustratingly hard to find at crossings like Nogales. About 11,000 vehicles a day crawl north across the border — carrying tourists, shoppers and workers, along with commerce ranging from Ford Broncos to tons of tomatoes. “A pill is very tiny,” said Michael Humphries, the U.S. Customs and Border Protection director of the Nogales, Arizona, border crossing. For smugglers, “concealment locations are pretty unlimited.”

U.S. officials have welcomed the Mexican reinforcements. “We need all the help we can get,” said one veteran antidrug official in Arizona. But the Mexicans’ lack of experience and classified intelligence makes it hard for them to detect fentanyl, said the official, who was not authorized to speak on the record.

SEE TROOPS ON A12

Members of the Mexican national guard head to a checkpoint on the southern edge of Nogales, Mexico, last month.

Flags raised as tech mogul polices his own conflicts

BY FAIZ SIDDIQUI
AND HANNAH NATANSON

When the Office of Personnel Management asked federal workers to explain what they did last week, the email landed with extra weight for workers at NASA’s Human Landing System program.

The program has a lunar lander contract with Blue Origin, the rocket company owned by Washington Post owner Jeff Bezos. Replying to the email could reveal details of that contract work to Blue Origin’s primary competitor: Billionaire Elon Musk, now a powerful adviser to President Donald Trump and also the founder of the rocket company SpaceX.

Initially, workers at NASA were told they didn’t need to respond to the email, according to a person familiar with the matter, who spoke on the condition of anonymity for fear of retribution. But then a program manager for HLS sent a note, a copy of which was obtained by The Washington Post, saying that she would reply

SEE EMAILS ON A17

The paint color that means gentrification

Accompanying demographic changes, shades of gray are permeating D.C. neighborhoods

BY MARISSA J. LANG
AND JOHN D. HARDEN

If you live in an American city, chances are you have seen this house:

Its exterior is gray with monochromatic accents.

Maybe there’s a pop of color — a red, blue or yellow door.

The landscaping is restrained, all clean lines and neat minimalism.

Sleek metal address numbers appear crisp in a modern sans-serif font.

Some might call it elegant, others boring. The look itself is purposely unremarkable. Real estate agents and paint companies use words such as “quiet,” “calm” and “neutral” to describe it.

But many longtime city-dwellers see this physical transformation of residences to muted tones and know what they signal: demographic, social and economic change.

Rowhouses in D.C., craftsmans in Nashville, Victorian-style homes in San Francisco and many other styles of houses in gentrifying neighborhoods across the country have in-



BILL O’LEARY/FOR THE WASHINGTON POST

Gray and neutral house colors are in the majority on this stretch of Adams Street NW in D.C.

creasingly been stripped of their colors and painted shades of gray, altering the aesthetics of American cities.

In some neighborhoods, the grayification of homes has been

swift and stark — and the cause of conflicts.

In the nation’s capital, residents have seen the change steadily sweeping their communities lot by lot: A neighbor’s

red-brick rowhouse goes up for sale with a fresh coat of paint. A residential block that once had vivid murals painted on the sides of buildings begins to look

SEE GENTRIFICATION ON A8

Cuomo enters NYC race with Trump as backdrop

BY SARAH ELLISON

NEW YORK — The most significant factor in the mayor’s race here may be living 240 miles away at 1600 Pennsylvania Avenue.

In a crowded field of mayoral aspirants, two Democrats with complicated relationships with President Donald Trump are poised to turn the race into a referendum on how New York voters want their city to engage with the current occupant of the White House.

Former governor Andrew M. Cuomo — who navigated a difficult relationship with Trump during his last term, often challenging him during the early days of the coronavirus pandemic — announced his run for mayor Saturday. Incumbent Eric Adams has been widely accused of cutting a deal with the president to keep himself out of prison, potentially fatally wounding his political fortunes in the deeply blue city. Adams has denied a quid pro quo.

SEE CUOMO ON A7

METRO
Prince George’s voters to choose a new executive during a critical time.

SPORTS
The NFL nearly broke Andrew Luck. He’s back in the game at Stanford.



ARTS & STYLE
We rank the recent films that brought new life to the beloved musical.

BUSINESS
Coffee prices are super caffeinated and are poised to only get higher.



BOOK WORLD
Samina Ali had to rebuild after a traumatic birth left her brain-damaged.

TRAVEL
L.A. wants you back: After January’s wildfires, business is way down.

\$210

SUNDAY
COUPON
INSERTS

CONTENT © 2025
The Washington Post / Year 148, No. 54143

